SWEN303 · GROUP 4 · RESEARCH

vuw clubs.

Research: how students go from
“I’d like to come” to “I know where to go”.

Interviews and analysis: Rui Meng Tong · 2026

This document collects the research behind vuw clubs.: problems I met myself, an observation of the university club directory, interviews to check them with other students, and a scenario for each persona. The personas, journey map and user tasks built from this research are in the Iteration 1 report (pp. 4–6).

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RESEARCH / STARTING POINT

Where this research started

As a student looking for clubs, I ran into the same problems several times. Club information was not kept up to date and was spread across Instagram, Facebook and club websites. On the university club directory I could not find when or where clubs meet, or other basic details. I missed recruitment events because I did not know their exact times. A message I sent to one club on Instagram has never been answered. I prefer to meet people in person, but recruitment events were so crowded that I found it hard to talk to anyone. I still wanted to find out about many clubs.

These are one person's experiences, so I treated them as assumptions to check: first by observing the directory itself, then by interviewing other students.

Four assumptions taken into the research

A1	The university directory does not tell students when and where clubs meet.
A2	Club information is scattered across social platforms and is not kept up to date.
A3	Contacting a club online is not a reliable way to get started.
A4	Recruitment events are easy to miss, and hard to use when they are crowded.

How they were checked

01 OBSERVE
Record what the university club directory shows, across all 158 club pages.
p. 3

02 INTERVIEW
Talk to three students, ending with a walkthrough of the same directory.
p. 4

03 COMPARE
Mark each assumption confirmed, partly confirmed or not.
p. 6

RESEARCH / OBSERVATION

Six of 158 clubs say when they meet

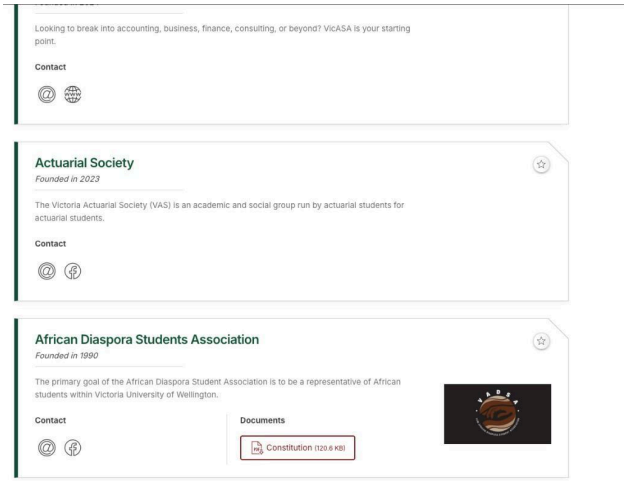
The problems in A1–A3 came from browsing the university's club directory before the interviews. To record them systematically, I reviewed every club page in the directory: 158 clubs. A script checked the text of each page for meeting days, times and places, and for links to other platforms. I then read every match by hand to remove false positives, such as "Sun" in the sailing club's description. The data is in research-assets/directory-review.csv.

6 of 158
give a meeting day and time

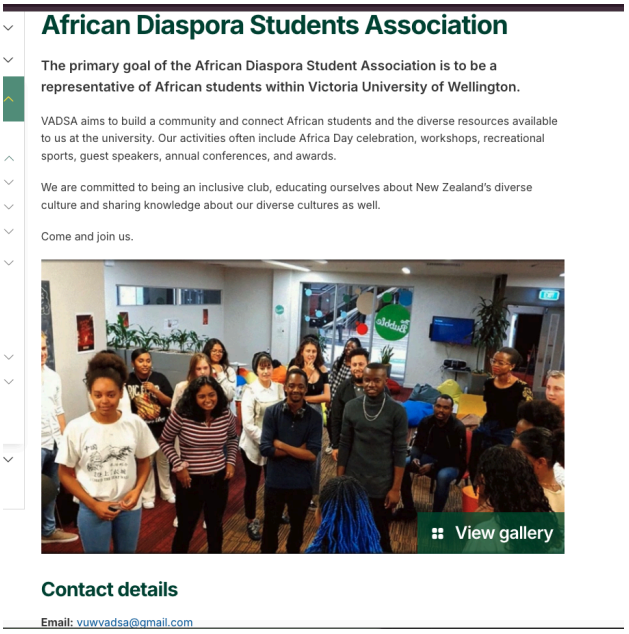
10 of 158
name a regular meeting day

111 of 158
link to Instagram; 112 to Facebook

83 of 158
have social media but no website of their own



Directory list: name, founding year, a one-line description and contact icons.



A club page: description, activities and a photo, then an email address. No time, place or joining step.

What I observed

O1 **When and where are missing.** Even clubs with weekly sessions rarely say when they meet. VicFolk, for example, gives none.

O2 **The details live somewhere else.** Most pages send students to Instagram or Facebook; 83 have no website of their own to hold lasting information.

O3 **Email is the main next step.** 157 of 158 pages list an email address. A student has to write to the club before knowing when to turn up.

RESEARCH / APPROACH

Three interviews and a directory walkthrough

To check whether other students meet the same problems, and to find ones I had missed, I interviewed three students one to one. Each interview ended with the participant using, or talking through, the same university club directory.

Participant	Age	Background	Directory walkthrough
Liv	22	Final year of two degrees (linguistics, computer science); member of a folk music club; class representative.	Finding a club she already knew, then browsing unfamiliar clubs and filters.
Theo	28	Third-year software engineering; previously studied contemporary music performance and worked in retail.	Demonstrated how he finds and shortlists clubs, and what signals a club is suitable.
Ben	21	Interests in dance, music, fashion and sport; has tried several clubs; class representative.	First impressions of a club page, and the site as the only way in.

How the interviews ran

- Semi-structured, one to one, interviewer Rui Meng Tong. Participants could skip any question or take a break.
- Topics: background and interests; how they make friends; clubs they have joined or left; how they find, choose and keep attending activities; then the directory walkthrough.
- Each interview was recorded and transcribed. Transcripts were edited for readability (repetition and small talk removed); they are in Appendix A

RESEARCH / INTERVIEW INSIGHTS

The interest is there. The practical details are not.

What the three interviews showed. Each insight appeared in more than one interview; the two marked “also noted” appeared less strongly.

INSIGHT 1

Interest does not become attendance without practical details

Liv had known about the folk music club since high school but only joined midway through her first university year. She had not encountered its meeting time and location, although she acknowledged she could have searched for them. During the website walkthrough, she again looked for when and where to attend. Theo also wanted the schedule directly on the club page. I noticed that interest alone was not enough: they needed practical details to turn that interest into a plan.

INSIGHT 2

Available time decides which clubs are even on the table

Liv wanted to find clubs she could attend first, then choose the ones that interested her. Theo explored clubs before the trimester and considered their schedules when arranging labs and tutorials. When a club meeting conflicted with a useful study workshop, he prioritised the workshop. These accounts showed me that timing is part of deciding which activity to choose.

INSIGHT 3

Students need to know what this particular session involves

Liv enjoyed singing and dancing but was still a beginner on the tin whistle. She skipped slow sessions when she did not know enough tunes to participate, even though those sessions were intended to help newer players. Knowing the weekly content helped her choose the sessions she valued. Theo responded positively to descriptions welcoming different ages and abilities. I noticed that students needed enough detail to judge what they would actually do and whether the session suited their experience.

INSIGHT 4

Pictures form the first impression

When I asked Theo about visuals, he said a page without a picture felt less engaging. Ben described the page's presentation as unexciting and discussed forming an impression from its image. Liv recalled being drawn to another club by a funny flyer and its QR-linked information. I noticed that visual presentation could attract attention and help communicate what an activity might feel like, alongside its practical details.

INSIGHT 5

Privacy and platform choice affect whether people engage

Theo does not use Instagram. He also said that public profiles for every club member could make him feel expected to disclose his own information and discourage him from joining. He was more receptive to short introductions to organisers. Liv said she would be unlikely to initiate contact through online member profiles. These responses made me question whether requiring more personal information or relying on a particular social platform would help these students participate.

ALSO NOTED

Clear updates help students keep participating

Liv valued weekly emails explaining the next session's activity and room in advance. This helped her decide whether to rearrange other commitments. Theo described uncertainty about whether meetings would happen during particular weeks or study breaks. He also found lasting information difficult to retrieve from old Discord messages and pins. I noticed a need for both clear ongoing arrangements and accessible updates about individual sessions.

ALSO NOTED

Friends are a way in, and asking comes before searching

Ben joined the Filipino club because his friends were there and said their company could make an event enjoyable even when he did not know all its details. He also described seeing volleyball at the recreation centre and asking whether he could join. Liv described friendships developing through repeated classes and group meetings. I noticed that familiar people and opportunities to take part in a shared activity mattered in these accounts of making connections.

What the observation and interviews confirmed

Each starting assumption against the directory review and the three interviews.

Assumption	Directory review	Interviews	Result
A1 Directory does not say when and where	6 of 158 pages give a day and time (O1).	During the walkthrough, Liv again looked for when and where to attend. Theo wanted the schedule on the club page (insight 1).	**Confirmed**
A2 Information is scattered and out of date	111 Instagram and 112 Facebook links; 83 clubs have no website (O2).	Liv: the club's own site appeared "not to have been updated in years". Theo does not use Instagram, and finds lasting information lost in old Discord messages (insight 5; also noted: updates).	**Confirmed**
A3 Contacting a club online is unreliable	Email is the main next step on 157 pages (O3).	Nobody reported an unanswered message. Ben asks people he knows first; Liv would not start contact through online member profiles.	**Partly**
A4 Recruitment events are easy to miss and crowded	Not covered by the directory.	Ben: "With a club expo, one limitation is that you could miss the day." Liv made friends through small, repeated contact rather than big events.	**Partly**

The interviews also raised needs I had not assumed: knowing what a particular session involves (insight 3), pictures as the first impression (insight 4), and privacy about personal details (insight 5). These shaped the personas (Iteration 1 report, p. 4) as much as the four assumptions did. Later, the Iteration 1 user tests confirmed A3 more directly: two of the three participants could not tell how to join from the club page (F1).

RESEARCH / EMPATHY MAP

Keen to come, unsure where to go

What the three interviewees thought, did, saw and said while looking for a club. Each note comes from the transcripts in Appendix A; dark notes are direct quotes.

Think

- "I already know I would like to come; I need to know where to go." — **Liv**
- Can a beginner keep up, or is this session for people who already know the tunes? — **Liv, Theo**
- Will I be the odd one out? Older than the others, or not as cool as them. — **Liv, Theo**
- "Meeting people can feel challenging or scary." — **Ben**

Do

- Opens interesting clubs in new tabs, then narrows the list before the trimester starts. — **Theo**
- Asks a friend first; joined a club because his friends were already there. — **Ben**
- Follows the club on Instagram and Facebook and waits for the weekly email. — **Liv**
- Moves other commitments when that week's activity is one she cares about. — **Liv**



See

- Club pages with a short description but no day, time or room. — **all three**
- Contact links to Instagram, Facebook and Discord, with old details lost in pinned posts. — **Theo**
- Pages without pictures that feel flat and "not especially exciting". — **Theo, Ben**
- A crowded start-of-year expo; funny flyers and QR codes around campus. — **Liv, Ben**

Say

- "Put the schedule somewhere clear… 'every Thursday at 2 pm.'" — **Theo**
- "My first question is why I cannot sort by when they meet." — **Liv**
- "With a club expo, one limitation is that you could miss the day." — **Ben**
- Profiles of every member would make him less willing to join. — **Theo**

PAIN

- Missing meetings because the day or room is unknown, or clashes with classes
- Details spread across social platforms and old messages
- Having to message strangers before the first visit

GAIN

- Day, time and room visible before opening a club
- Knowing what this week involves and whether beginners fit
- An easy first step in, ideally with a familiar face

RESEARCH / SCENARIOS

Liv: fitting a club around a full week

Persona: Liv, The Selective Participant. Tasks: T1, T2, T4. Each persona has three scenarios: what happens today (as-is), the same goal with the Iteration 1 design (to-be), and how the Iteration 1 user test checked it (evaluation). Personas and tasks are in the Iteration 1 report, pp. 4 and 6.

AS-IS

Today, with the university directory

Environment: Sunday evening at home on her laptop, with next week's timetable open. She is in the final year of two degrees, and several weekday evenings are already taken.

Events: A few clubs sound interesting, so she opens the university club directory. The club pages describe each club but do not say when or where it meets, so she opens Instagram and club websites one by one. Where she does find a weekly session, she still cannot tell what this week involves, or whether a session labelled for beginners assumes skills she does not have.

Information: Short descriptions and contact icons in the directory; meeting times only on some clubs' own channels; the weekly email only once she is on a club's list.

Friction points:

- No meeting day or time in the directory (O1).
- Details spread across several platforms.
- What a session involves is unknown until the weekly email.
- Clashes with classes show up only after she has missed weeks, as happened last year.

TO-BE

With the Iteration 1 design

Environment: The same evening, laptop and timetable.

Events: She filters by the evenings she is free and keeps a short list of clubs that meet then. On VicFolk's page, the video, this week's plan and the first-visit note tell her whether Thursday is for her, and she can contact the club without Instagram. Step by step: flows T1 and T2 + T3, Iteration 1 report pages 8 and 9.

Information: Meeting day, time and room on every club; this week's plan; what a beginner can expect; a "last checked" date beside the time.

Friction addressed:

- Times are visible before she opens a club (T1).
- Session content and beginner fit are on the club page (T2).
- The "last checked" date tells her when to confirm with the club (T4).

EVALUATION

How Iteration 1 testing checked it

Session: Session 2, about 41 minutes, led by Himani Rakesh Amin, with a senior student in a folk-music club who matches the Liv persona. The site was demonstrated first.

Task given: "Go and join a club."

What we watch: Where she looks first for how to join; whether she reads say-hi.mail as a way to join; whether she checks the time and room before deciding; how she reacts to the fonts and colours.

Success looks like: She reaches a clear next step to join from the club page, knows when and where to turn up, and needs neither Instagram nor the facilitator.

RESEARCH / SCENARIOS

Theo: planning a first visit before the trimester

Persona: Theo, The Advance Planner. Tasks: T1, T3, T4.

AS-IS

Today, with the university directory

Environment: The week before the trimester, at his desk with his new timetable of lectures, labs and study support. He does not use Instagram.

Events: He browses the directory broadly before narrowing down. For a club he likes, he wants plain facts: when it meets, whether beginners are welcome, and whether he must register first. Those details sit in Instagram posts he cannot see, or in guides buried under weeks of chat messages. Later in the trimester he cannot tell whether the club is meeting that week or during the study break.

Information: Club descriptions and contact links; joining guides in old chat messages; weekly changes posted only on social media.

Friction points:

- Essential details need an Instagram account.
- Guides are buried in chat history.
- No reliable plan for each week or the study break.
- Clashes with study support are found late.

TO-BE

With the Iteration 1 design

Environment: The same week, at the same desk.

Events: He filters by his free evenings. Clubs that publish no time stay in the list but dimmed, so he knows which ones to ask. The first-visit note tells him what to bring and expect, and he emails a club for its time without Instagram. Before going again he checks this week's note and the "last checked" date (flow T4, Iteration 1 report p. 10).

Information: Published times, or a clear note that a club does not publish them; first-visit essentials; an email route with no social media; saved clubs stay in his browser, with no account or profile.

Friction addressed:

- Clubs can be compared against his timetable (T1).
- First-visit details and a way to ask, without Instagram (T3).
- The weekly note and the "last checked" date (T4).

EVALUATION

How Iteration 1 testing checked it

Session: Session 3, about 25 minutes, led by Fanfu and Adam, with Theo. He explored two visual versions of the site first.

Tasks given: Compare two clubs; fit a club around a timetable; try a club with none in mind.

What we watch: Which details he compares and where he finds them; whether he uses the day toggles; whether he finds first-visit and joining details without leaving the site; which visual version he prefers.

Success looks like: He names a club that fits his timetable, says when and where it meets and how to join, and needs neither social media nor the facilitator.

RESEARCH / SCENARIOS

Ben: checking out a club a friend mentioned

Persona: Ben, The Social Explorer. Tasks: T2, T3, T5.

AS-IS

Today, with the university directory

Environment: On his phone between classes, after a friend mentions VUCC, the canoe club, over lunch.

Events: He would rather ask his friend than search, but wants to see what the club is like before going. He looks it up in the university directory and finds a short description and contact icons, with little to show what a session looks like. He cannot tell whether beginners go, or when and where to turn up, so he goes back to asking his friend.

Information: A short description, a logo and contact icons; whatever his friend remembers.

Friction points:

- Little visual context, and a plain first impression.
- When, where and how to join are missing (O1).
- The website does not help unless someone he knows is already going.

TO-BE

With the Iteration 1 design

Environment: The same phone, the same break.

Events: He opens VUCC by name. A video, photos and members' own words show what a session looks like. The top of the page gives Thursdays 7:45pm at Freyberg Pool, and the first-visit note says beginners start at the pool session. He sends his friend the time and they plan to go together.

Information: Video, photos and members' own words; time and place at the top of the page; what a first session involves.

Friction addressed:

- He can see the activity before going (T2).
- He reaches the club from the name he heard (T5).
- When, where and how to start, without asking anyone (T3).

EVALUATION

How Iteration 1 testing checked it

Session: Session 1, led by Rui Meng Tong, with Ben, thinking aloud. Free exploration first; the facilitator answered questions as they came up.

Tasks given: Find a club he would join; find a club at a time that suits him and compare it.

What we watch: What catches his eye first on the home page and a club page; whether video and photos help him judge the activity; whether he finds the time and place without asking; how he compares clubs.

Success looks like: He can describe what a club's session involves from the page alone, chooses one he would join, and finds when and where it meets.

APPENDIX A

Interview transcripts

Edited for readability; not a verbatim record. Repetition and incidental small talk are omitted. Where an interviewer question was not captured, the section heading gives its topic.

Liv

Age: 22 | Interviewer: Rui Meng Tong

Introduction and consent to skip questions

Rui Meng: Thank you for coming. Please tell me if you need a break, if I speak too quickly, or if there is a question you would prefer to skip. Could you introduce yourself, including your background, studies, hobbies and anything else you would like to share?

Liv: I am 22 and have lived in Wellington my whole life. I did not move here for university. I am in my fifth and final year, studying two degrees: a Bachelor of Arts with a major in linguistics and a minor in anthropology, and a Bachelor of Science in computer science. That is why I am taking this course.

Music and other hobbies

Liv: I am in a folk music club. We dance, sing and play music. I play the tin whistle badly because I only use it at club meetings. It is a small metal instrument, rather like a recorder, but the one I use has holes on the front rather than the extra thumb hole on the back. I bought it so I could play along with the tunes taught at the club. I play piano much better and have played it for a long time. I also sing, dance and make things. I have many hobbies; I am a generalist at heart.

Describing personality

Rui Meng: How would you describe your personality? Would you describe yourself as introverted or extroverted?

Liv: I talk a lot. I do not really believe that everyone fits neatly into those two categories, but if I had to choose, I would be more extroverted. I am the person who starts a conversation when we are told to discuss something in class and nobody is speaking.

When speaking up feels easier or harder

Rui Meng: Does that depend on the environment? Can you give a specific example? You mentioned being a woman—why does that matter here?

Liv: I am more outgoing when I feel I do not have much to lose. In a class discussion, I might look a little silly, but I can gain a lot of learning. I speak much less when a technical course asks for one correct answer to a maths problem. As a woman in engineering and computer science, I worry that getting a technical answer wrong will affect how people judge my ability and whether they trust my opinions later. I also worry about embarrassment and do not always trust my own skills.

Maths confidence and assessment

Liv: I grew up thinking I was bad at maths, although I am actually quite good at it. I was bad at timed tests. As a child, we had checks with around 100 questions in five minutes. I could do the maths but could not finish that quickly. Those experiences stayed with me. I am more confident in discussions with several possible contributions than in situations where everyone is waiting for a single correct answer. In discussions, it is hard to stop me talking; with technical questions, it can be hard to get me to speak.

Making friends

Rui Meng: I invited you partly because you are a class representative and seem interested in connecting with people. How do you make friends?

Liv: Do you mean at university or in general?

Rui Meng: In general.

Liv: I talk to people, but the important part is arranging to be around people I want to become friends with. My understanding is that making friends becomes harder when people spend less time together. At school, you repeatedly see the same people. I try to create more opportunities for that repeated contact.

Friendship through a group project

Liv: I made friends through a previous group project. We sat together in the classes we shared, met in person about once a week for the project, and talked outside the work itself. We became friends because we spent more time around each other.

Approaching people after a long delay

Liv: There were people I wanted to be friends with from my first year, but I thought they were too cool for me. I spent about two years thinking that. In my third year, I realised they were going to graduate and we might never become friends. I started asking whether they wanted lunch and where they were going after class. They had a place on campus where they studied with friends. After trying to judge whether I was welcome, I spent time there when I was free. The repeated contact helped us become friends.

What might have helped earlier

Rui Meng: If you could go back to your first year, what might have made it easier to make friends?

Liv: For a long time, I did not even know their names. We shared classes and sometimes complimented one another's outfits, but there was no easy moment to ask. In our small discussion-based classes, a simple name game or icebreaker at the start could have helped.

Entering first-year ECS classes later

Rui Meng: Was the situation different in your engineering and computer science classes?

Liv: I started taking first-year ECS courses in my third year. There were many students, and I was around 20 while many of them were around 18. I did not immediately want to join their conversations. They had recently left high school, shared jokes and memes I did not understand, and I felt awkward about the age difference.

Rui Meng: Had someone been mean to you, and was that why you were worried?

Liv: No. It was mainly the awkwardness of being 20 among 18-year-olds. In my original first year, the issue had been different: I simply thought the people I wanted to know were too cool for me. We also sat in different parts of the room.

What made those classmates appealing

Rui Meng: What made you think they were cool?

Liv: In discussions, I would try to express an idea, and later they would say something similar but phrase it more clearly or add an insightful perspective. I thought they understood it better. Later, I realised we had different discussion styles. I was trying to make my language accessible to the whole room, while they were using more specialised language. Now that we are friends, I can also joke about them being idiots.

Reaction to an online profile idea

Rui Meng: If a website showed people's names and backgrounds and let you contact them, would that be a way you would prefer to meet them?

Liv: I do not think I would reach out. I rarely initiate contact online. I am more of an in-person person.

What club friendships mean

Rui Meng: Have you made friends through your club?

Liv: Yes. We are friendly enough that I would help them move house if they asked, but we do not generally meet outside folk-music-related settings. If I go to another folk music event, such as singing at the Welsh Dragon, I look for the people I know from the club and sit with them rather than with strangers.

Knowing about the folk music club

Rui Meng: How did you first find out about the club?

Liv: I grew up in Wellington and had been involved in folk music since childhood. I knew the university club existed from when it was founded, while I was still at high school. I already knew that attending this university would give me access to that club.

Joining a different club first

Rui Meng: If you already knew about it, how and when did you join?

Liv: I joined a different club for the first half of my first year. The people were lovely and I had social connections there, but we did not become close friends. Many had already graduated, were older, and had different interests and circumstances. We had the club in common but not much else. Although I already knew about the folk music club, I did not join it until halfway through that year because I did not know which day it met or where.

Why the timing of discovery mattered

Rui Meng: How did you eventually find the meeting details?

Liv: I had not actively looked for them. If I had searched, I probably could have found them, but I had not come across them. At the start-of-year club expo, I was overwhelmed by being a first-year student and by everything happening. I had joined the other club after seeing funny flyers around campus and scanning a QR code that made it look enjoyable. By the midyear club expo, I knew the university better and there were fewer competing events. I found the folk music club there, saw when and where it met, and signed up.

Missing meetings despite wanting to attend

Rui Meng: Have you missed activities? What has been frustrating about the organisation or arrangements?

Liv: I missed many weekly meetings last year. I was taking second-year computer science courses, and software engineering assignments and exams often fell on Thursday evenings, when the club met. Sometimes I was finishing an assignment, preparing for an exam, or actually sitting an exam. The club had also moved from 7–9 pm to 6–8 pm because the later finish was difficult for some people. If my exam ended at 7:30 pm, most of the meeting was already over. It was a combination of workload and unfortunate timing.

Other commitments and travel

Liv: The club changed its meeting day but kept the 6–8 pm time. I moved another weekly commitment to accommodate it, although I still cannot always attend. I live across town, and sometimes I have childcare responsibilities that make reaching university by 6 pm difficult.

Organisation that helps

Rui Meng: What do you think the club organises well?

Liv: My favourite thing is the email they send every week, a few days before the meeting. It says what we will do and which room we will use. Room bookings have sometimes changed, so that matters. If the activity is something I particularly care about, I can rearrange things to attend. If it is not, I can choose to miss that week.

Deciding between different activities

Rui Meng: So you need a fuller description that could increase your interest and help you rearrange your schedule?

Liv: Sometimes the club goes to a slow session instead of holding its usual meeting. A folk session involves playing tunes together, joining in when you know them. The slow version helps people begin participating. They play more slowly and tell people more in advance about the tunes they plan to play, but I still do not know enough tunes on the tin whistle. I only play it at weekly meetings and do not practise separately. I enjoy the social side of learning that week's tune, but I cannot really participate in a slow session.

Rui Meng: Does that make you feel awkward?

Liv: It actually makes the decision easier. If the email says we are going to the slow session, I can focus on other things that week. If it says we are dancing, I will move other commitments because dancing and singing are my favourite activities.

Being a beginner at dancing

Rui Meng: That sounds interesting. I cannot dance because I am not very coordinated.

Liv: They teach each dance before we do it together. People from young children to much older adults can do this kind of dancing, and you are not expected to be good already.

Website walkthrough: finding a known club

Rui Meng: Could you show me how you would browse the university's club website?

Liv: I would use it to find a club. I would search for "folk," open Vic Folk, read the short description and look at the contact details. I would open its Instagram and Facebook pages and follow them. I use Instagram more, but I know that many folk music activities are organised through Facebook.

Looking for practical details

Liv: I would expect the club's own website to say when the weekly meetings happen. Looking at it now, it appears not to have been updated in years, so it is not useful for that. If I felt brave, I could email and ask when and where they meet. But I did not actually do that when I first wanted to join; I eventually got the details at the expo. A club directory should help me find the actual meeting, not just tell me the club exists.

Browsing unfamiliar clubs

Rui Meng: Have you looked at other clubs on this website? What comes to mind when you browse it?

Liv: Sometimes I scroll through and notice clubs that sound interesting. My first question is why I cannot sort by when they meet. The main barrier to participating is whether the meeting conflicts with something I already do. I also want to know whether they meet weekly or use some other pattern.

Filters and categories

Liv: The university's course finder has filters such as semester, morning or afternoon, and course level. I would like practical filters like that for clubs. Broad categories such as "science and technology" tell me little compared with the club's name and description. I would first find clubs I can attend, then read about those and choose the ones that interest me.

Reading the description aloud

Rui Meng: As you look through this club page, could you tell me what attracts your attention and what you skim past?

Liv: I notice that it involves students learning, playing and dancing to Irish and Scottish music; that students and alumni can participate; and that the weekly meetings sound relaxed. Those are appealing. But I still want to know where and when the meetings happen. The description repeats that there is music and dance and mentions regular workshops without explaining how regular they are. It also says I do not need to have danced before. I already know I would like to come; I need to know where to go.

Rui Meng: Thank you for sharing. I think that covers what I needed to learn from you.

Liv: I am glad it was helpful.

Theo

Age: 28 | Interviewer: Rui Meng Tong

Background and studies

Rui Meng: Could you introduce yourself, including your background and what you study?

Theo: I am in the third year of a four-year Bachelor of Engineering, majoring in software engineering. Before Victoria University, I completed a certificate in contemporary music performance. I decided not to pursue music as a career, worked in retail and supermarkets for a few years, and then came to university.

Beginning music

Rui Meng: Today I want to explore engagement with university clubs. You have an interesting music background. What first brought you into music?

Theo: At intermediate school, instrument lessons became available. My sister had a drum kit in the garage, so I had both an instrument and access to classes. I decided to try it and did well in music class. I joined musical extracurricular activities, including a school orchestra and a separate band of about five people.

Orchestra and band experiences

Rui Meng: You said the orchestra had a drum kit "for some reason." What did you mean? Was the five-person band the same group?

Theo: A standard drum kit is not usually the main setup in an orchestral percussion section. You would more often have particular percussion instruments, such as a cymbal, a large drum or a xylophone-type instrument. But this was intermediate school, and they had someone who could play drums, so they included me. The five-person band was separate. We had guitarists, a singer and a rapper. We recorded an original song and made a CD, which I still have.

What he enjoyed about performing

Rui Meng: How did that experience feel? What did you enjoy most about working with them?

Theo: I enjoyed performing, being on stage, having people listen and receiving recognition. I preferred being a supporting member of the team rather than the centre of attention. That was part of why I gravitated towards drums.

Personality and becoming comfortable

Rui Meng: Are you familiar with MBTI? How would you describe your personality—for example, introverted or extroverted?

Theo: Do you mean now or back then?

Rui Meng: Now.

Theo: I am more extroverted than I used to be, but I need time to warm up. With unfamiliar people in a small group, I am usually quiet, observe what is happening and wait for a suitable time to join the conversation. Once I am comfortable, I talk a lot and can become a distraction, although we still get our work done.

Example from a project group

Rui Meng: Could you give an example? You can skip anything you do not want to answer.

Theo: In our university group project, I let other people lead the first few meetings while I got to know the group. As I became more comfortable, I could participate and lead more myself. After about six months together, I am much more talkative in meetings.

Early club participation

Rui Meng: Is it similar when you meet people socially, such as joining a club?

Theo: I tried a few clubs in first year but did not stay involved long enough to become comfortable. Their organisation and communication felt poor. It was unclear whether they were meeting that week or whether

activities continued during study breaks. Knowing when I needed to be there felt more difficult than it should have been.

Finding and shortlisting clubs

Rui Meng: How did you find those clubs?

Theo: I used the university website's alphabetical list. I went from top to bottom and opened anything vaguely interesting in a new tab. Then I went through those tabs one by one, read more and narrowed the list. If something sounded enjoyable and like something I could do, I followed the contact or joining instructions. I did this before classes started so I could be prepared, then went to the first sessions.

Demonstrating the browsing process

Rui Meng: Could you show me the whole process on the website, including what you look at first?

Theo: I scan the names and skip clubs that do not apply to me. If something such as badminton or board games sounds interesting, I open a new tab and continue down the list. Once I have finished, I return to those tabs and read the details. For example, I might see the contact platforms and decide I do not want to use them, then close the tab.

Rui Meng: Why would you not want to use those platforms?

Theo: That was just an example of a reason to close a tab, not a statement that I dislike those specific platforms.

Signals that a club is suitable

Rui Meng: Is the information enough to make you want to join, or is anything missing that would make it better?

Theo: A description saying it is friendly and welcomes a range of abilities is appealing because I would be an absolute beginner. "All ages" also appeals to me because I am an older student. I would read the information sheet for new players and follow the instructions if it sounded good. Whether the information is sufficient depends on the particular club.

Instagram as a possible obstacle

Rui Meng: Have you joined this other club? Its regular events are posted on Instagram and other social media.

Theo: I have seen it before, but I thought it was a one-off event rather than an actual club. I have not joined it. I do not have Instagram, so using that as the main communication channel would be a hurdle. I could imagine attending the first session, asking when the next one happens, and being told to look on Instagram. That would make continuing difficult for me.

Exploring without a fixed club in mind

Rui Meng: Is there anything else I should know about how you browse?

Theo: I do not normally arrive with one specific club in mind, such as rock climbing. I look at the full list, see what exists and choose from that.

Reaction to images

Rui Meng: Would you like more visual elements on the website?

Theo: I think so. Looking at this chess club page without pictures, I feel less engaged and would like to see an image. The text saying all skill levels are welcome is useful because it suggests an absolute beginner could attend.

The social value of the activity itself

Rui Meng: What else stands out in the description?

Theo: Extra social events are not a major attraction for me. Going to the club's normal activity already counts as a social event. Something additional, such as a pub quiz with the chess club, is another step that does not particularly influence my decision.

Reaction to joining without contacting someone first

Rui Meng: Imagine you could find a club online and join its group by clicking, without first contacting anyone. Would that feel less stressful?

Theo: I suppose so. I usually decide which clubs to try before the first trimester begins, before the club expo. By the time people have their expo stalls, I have often already chosen a few clubs.

Arranging study around clubs

Theo: I have to plan my study timetable around the activities. If a club meets on Wednesday afternoon, I need to avoid booking a lab or tutorial at that time if I want to attend.

A specific timetable conflict

Theo: That reminds me of a first-year experience. ECS workshops ran on Monday and Wednesday evenings, from about 6 to 8:30 pm. I discovered them halfway through the first trimester and found them so helpful that I attended every one. One of my clubs met at the same time on Monday, so I could no longer go to that club meeting because I prioritised the study support.

Rui Meng: So that was the main reason?

Theo: It was a big reason. They also met at midday on Saturdays, but that timing was difficult for me. It interrupted what I could do in the morning, and I felt tired afterwards, which affected the afternoon as well.

Making arrangements easier to understand

Rui Meng: What changes to the organisation would make planning easier?

Theo: Put the schedule somewhere clear. I do not see why the page we are looking at cannot simply say when the club meets, such as “every Thursday at 2 pm.”

Rui Meng: So you want more information to help you decide?

Theo: Just practical information, really.

Continuity between club committees

Rui Meng: What could change about the clubs you found disorganised that might make you want to join again?

Theo: Clubs hold annual general meetings, and the people running them can change substantially. A whole new committee might have a different timetable and different ways of organising and communicating. That can make continuity difficult.

Discord and long-term information

Rui Meng: How could information be communicated better? Do you like using Discord?

Theo: Discord is useful for immediate text and voice communication, but I do not like using it for information that needs to remain easy to find. Organisations sometimes put resources, FAQs and wiki-type material in channels or old pinned messages. Finding a beginner’s guide pinned six months ago can be unnecessarily difficult. A website could have a clearly organised resources or FAQ section instead.

Clarifying the earlier hiking-club comment

Rui Meng: I remember you saying a hiking club might be better organised. Is that an example?

Theo: I do not know whether it is better. Hiking was simply something I mentioned off the top of my head. Perhaps I happened to try several clubs with poor organisation, or perhaps the problem is broader. I do not know.

Rui Meng: I have little club experience myself. I joined the German club, where people share food during the weekend.

Theo: What did you find about the German club? Are you still involved?

Rui Meng: I went to the expo, asked people, got contact details and joined.

Finding people through music

Rui Meng: You have several hobbies and an interest in music production. Have you looked for people with those interests?

Theo: I have meant to visit the music school and see whether it has a noticeboard or information about activities. I have not got around to it, although I would like to before graduating. With some of my other hobbies, I do not necessarily want to be friends with the audiences they attract, and I do not want to say more about that. I have hobbies I do not necessarily want to share with other people who have the same interests.

The limit of his current music experience

Rui Meng: Would you prefer to talk more about music, then? Are you still doing it?

Theo: I have not actually tried to join a music club or a music-making social scene since my earlier studies, so it is difficult to describe an experience I have not had. I hope to do more over summer because it relates to a job I have lined up. Until then, I am focusing on my upcoming exams.

Learning music production

Rui Meng: How were you introduced to music production? Was it through friends, online posts or your studies?

Theo: Through my studies. The certificate focused on live performance, but it included other activities such as music production. I first encountered that after finishing high school. The course was at a polytechnic-type institution with a music school, not a university. They taught other subjects as well.

Social contact in the earlier course

Rui Meng: Did you join clubs or activities at that institution to make friends?

Theo: The structure was closer to school: roughly 9 am until 3 or 4 pm, Monday to Friday.

Rui Meng: So you had a lot of time?

Theo: There was less self-directed time than at university. Most of the day was in class, leaving less room for separate club activities. But the class itself made connecting easy. There were about 20 people, we were doing the same music-performance course, and we shared an interest.

Shared background and friendship

Rui Meng: Do you prefer to make friends through shared interests or a similar background?

Theo: I am generally open. A shared interest or some common background makes it easier to start. For example, discovering that someone at university comes from the same part of the country or attended the same school can break the ice.

Reaction to public member profiles

Rui Meng: Could showing club members' backgrounds and interests help beginners feel able to join?

Theo: I would not want to see that for every member. I would feel that joining meant I was expected to share that information about myself. Brief introductions to the people running the club, such as the president, vice-president or treasurer, might help. They would not need to be full life stories. But a page showing personal information about every member would make me less willing to join.

Privacy and closing

Rui Meng: Do you like sharing your background with other people?

Theo: In person, yes. I am less comfortable sharing it online and generally disclose only what is required. That is why I dislike the emphasis on personal information on LinkedIn. My profile contains what I need for employment and little else.

Rui Meng: Is there anything else you would like to add?

Theo: No, I think this is a good place to finish. We have talked about it quite a bit.

Rui Meng: Thank you for your time.

Theo: You are welcome.

Ben

Age: 21 | Interviewer: Rui Meng Tong

Introduction and university routine

Rui Meng: Could you introduce yourself and tell me about your routine and hobbies?

Ben: I am Ben. I go to campus almost every day except Sunday. Trying to do everything on my own can be tiring. Even when I have only about half my usual energy, I may learn something from a lecturer, tutor or friend that helps me work more efficiently during the week. I like working hard and learning how to work smarter. I want to grow in knowledge and wisdom and use that across my life.

Interests and involvement

Ben: I am Christian, and I think about developing the talents I have been given. I enjoy dance, music, clothing and fashion, social media content, and sport. I am interested in many things rather than putting all my energy into one speciality. Examples include volleyball, martial arts, swimming, boxing, calisthenics, powerlifting and bodybuilding. I have also been a class representative for several courses and have been involved with societies.

Getting to know people

Ben: I introduce myself and ask people what they like doing. If we share a course or university, that provides a starting point. I try to learn about the person and let common ground emerge naturally, even if we differ in personality, age or interests. I like talking to people, but I have also had times when I did not have many people to talk to. I had to be brave and start with something simple, such as asking someone's name. I try to get to know who they are rather than staying only with superficial questions.

A friend inviting him to a club

Ben: After getting to know someone, they invited me to try a club. I asked where to go and they gave me the details, although I did not know everything about it beforehand.

Different discovery channels

Rui Meng: So do you mainly hear about university clubs through other people introducing them?

Ben: There is also the club expo, where students set up tables in the university hub or foyer. I believe there is a website, although I have not naturally felt drawn to searching it for a club. If I wanted to find one, I could look at a website for activities and dates and ask people I know for more information.

A hypothetical search for a new club

Rui Meng: Which of those approaches would you prefer?

Ben: If I wanted to find a volleyball or rock-climbing club, I would first ask whether anyone I know has that interest or knows a club. If not, I would look online, including the university's club page.

Clubs he has tried

Ben: I tried archery for a day or two. I joined the Filipino club because my friends were there and participated during the earlier part of university. Even when you do not fully understand what will happen at an event, being with people you know can make it enjoyable.

Joining across cultural backgrounds

Ben: I have friends involved in leading other societies, including an African club and an Indian organisation. I have been to the African club and helped with pizza boxes. I was the only Filipino there that time. In my experience, the Filipino club and the other club welcomed people without requiring them to belong to that background.

Types of activities

Ben: There have been food events, movie nights, dance and talent shows, karaoke, and a horror-themed activity. They were spread through the year. I did not attend every event.

Following a club on social media

Ben: Once I know the club's name, I can look it up on social media and then see its posts in my feed. I would search for it rather than simply wait for it to appear naturally on Instagram. That is how I would approach it.

Advantages and limits of the discovery channels

Ben: A friend's recommendation can be appealing because I enjoy their company, and we may share interests. With a club expo, one limitation is that you could miss the day. A website requires active searching, although that is reasonable if you want to find a club; it also needs to contain the relevant clubs and information. Word of mouth is more difficult when you do not know many people. You might need to meet more people, look for shared interests, or try an unfamiliar activity outside your comfort zone.

Meeting unfamiliar people

Ben: Meeting people can feel challenging or scary, but the more people I meet, the more I remember that they are human too. We share ordinary experiences even if our personalities, topics or ways of doing things differ. I want company and connection. I am open to meeting people from different backgrounds if we can find common ground, while still having personal boundaries. For example, I am not interested in drinking or drugs.

Ideas for welcoming people

Ben: I would suggest icebreakers. For a class, team or event, an open-ended question can give people a way to contribute. People generally want to be included, heard and accepted, even if they do not agree on everything, although I think introverted people may be different. Examples might be which superpower they would choose and why, which animal they like and why, or which two colours they would mix and why. People can answer in different ways.

First impressions and the webpage

Ben: A first impression gives an initial idea. On the page, I can see clubs, an information sheet, contact details and a Facebook link. I have not used Facebook for a while.

Comparing contact-first and click-to-join approaches

Rui Meng: Some clubs give you contact details and expect you to ask for information. Some event apps let you click to enter a group without asking someone first. Which approach would interest you more?

Ben: To be honest, I have not experienced either of those approaches in that form.

A concrete walk-up experience

Ben: With volleyball, I saw it happening at the recreation centre as I passed by and asked whether it was casual and whether I could join. That was an opportunity I encountered in person.

Imagining the website as the only entry point

Rui Meng: What if this page were all you had to go on?

Ben: I am not sure I would naturally go out of my way based only on this. If I did not know the club, the people or how it worked, I might contact them, perhaps by phone, and try attending one day. Judging from the image and page, it is not especially exciting as advertising. The in-person experience might feel different when I see the people and what is actually happening.

Closing

Rui Meng: Thank you for your time.